MONTHLY UPDATE

# Lesotho: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-12 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.*

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · DATA

## Summary of the month

The revised Electronic Transactions and Communications Bill went to a stakeholder validation workshop from 28 September, and a second consultation was held on the Cybersecurity Bill. The national single window has twelve agencies connected, and a whole-of-government payment gateway is being developed for the central bank to run. Census enumeration is complete, with mop-up operations still running in Maseru on 17 September. A US$6.2bn hydropower and AI data centre agreement was signed, with a feasibility study to follow.

## Governance

### Legislation and regulation

The Cybersecurity Bill 2026 then went back to stakeholders: its draft was circulated for review in August and taken to a second consultation workshop on 23 September, proposing a two-tier regulatory regime and the registration of cybersecurity professionals.

The communications ministry took the Electronic Transactions and Communications Bill, 2026 to a stakeholder validation workshop in Maseru from 28 September, with UNDP support. It revises the unenacted 2022 Bill and goes next to the Office of the Parliamentary Counsel; the revised text is not held.

### Data protection

The ICT ministry's principal secretary told UNGA81 side meetings that the ministry had developed DPI Safeguards for Children with UNICEF Lesotho and is piloting them with the National University of Lesotho across five government ministries (23 September). Neither the text of the safeguards nor the ministries in the pilot are named.

### Regional collaboration

The border is to be digitised from both sides: the Bi-National Commission's mid-term review agreed to accelerate smart one-stop border posts at Maseru and Ficksburg, with no design or date published. The communications authority and Eswatini's regulator signed a memorandum providing for cybersecurity cooperation, including coordinated incident response, and exchange of information and resources.

## ICT Infrastructure

### Connectivity

Vodacom Lesotho launched a fully managed enterprise satellite service built on Starlink in Maseru, reported 9 October 2026, offered as primary connectivity, as backup and combined with terrestrial links.

### Data Storage

Kobong stayed an envelope, not money. Reporting in September restated the US$6.2 billion hydropower and AI data-centre agreement with Convalt Energy as the largest foreign investment deal Lesotho has signed, with a feasibility study to run over the next year before any implementation agreement or construction. The same report found that a local firm the energy minister named as a potential partner is part-owned by the public works minister, who said he would recuse himself from cabinet discussion of the project.

## DPI

### Data Exchange

The national single window has twelve agencies connected and cost M50m to design and implement, on the financing project's account reported on 27 September. It runs without its own law, drafting of which has started, and the government payment gateway is still to be integrated.

### Digital Payments and Fintech

A whole-of-government e-payment gateway is being developed, to be run by the central bank and integrated with the national single window, reported on 27 September. The dominant operator launched electronic airtime top-up without physical vouchers in the week of 4 September.

### Registries

No national address register exists. The communications regulator visited Kenya's regulator in September to benchmark its national addressing system and legal framework.

Government reported that a World Bank urban and land team expressed interest in supporting a nationwide digital address system; no commitment or amount is stated.

### Other GovTech and e-Gov

The data blueprint opened in July reached validation in September. A national workshop in Maseru with Smart Africa and GIZ validated the draft Data Value Creation Blueprint, the first country to do so, reviewing its vision, pillars, use cases and a diagnostic that calls the country's data landscape emerging but fragmented. Validation is not adoption, and the text is not published.

## Technology

### AI

At the second UN Digital Cooperation Day the prime minister said Lesotho was the first country to implement the UN AI Blueprint, that planning was complete and that Phase One of a National Compute Roadmap running 2026 to 2029 had begun (23 September). The roadmap is not published, and no source relates it to the data-centre roadmap drafted in August.

## Capacity

### Training and skills

Government said efforts are under way to establish the Smart Africa Digital Academy in the country, with no host institution, budget or opening date stated.

## Data

### National statistics

Census enumeration is complete, with mop-up operations still running in Maseru on 17 September 2026; it is the first census to ask questions recognising gender identity and sexuality. A second phase of the mapping of financial access points was tendered in September, to update the 2018 baseline across the ten districts.

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